Q+A

Kitchen Conductor

*Celebrity chef **Gaggan Anand** is back in India after temporarily closing his celebrated restaurant in Bangkok*

Q. Has it been a long time since you were last in India?
I've come to India several times earlier, but it's the first time I'm here to cook since I temporarily closed down my restaurant in Bangkok. I'm coming with my team of 14 to create the full Gaggan experience. No other Indian chef has come back to do a restaurant.

Q. Is this a food residency or something more?
For most people, it's a food residency. But some will know that it is more than that. I'm testing the waters and want to know how many *magarmachchhes* (crocodiles) are in it.

Q. What is your most recent discovery about Indian food?
I have recently discovered that the best food comes from very humble places, where people queue up for food. The longer the queue, the tastier the food. What is photographed is not the best.

Q. Having trained under the god of molecular gastronomy, Ferran Adrià, what does the food experience mean to you?
I want to serve a total sensory experience of not just five senses but six; it's an experience of the visual, texture, sound, taste, smell and the sixth-sense surprise, which is vital for me.

Q. Food as art or food as taste—what is closer to you?
When seen, it should look like art, like a painting where you can't see anything else. But when put in your mouth, it must taste like originality, transporting you to the *galli* (lane) of your childhood.

Q. What is your favourite Indian dish?
Dal-chawal any day. *Dal* with just a *jeere ka chhounk* (tempering of cumin) and *ghar ka achar* (homemade pickle). I want it to be my last meal before I die.

Q. What is your favourite Indian ingredient?
That has to be mustard oil. It is the most underrated ingredient—it's even banned in England. It is amazing to marry it with diverse flavours . The other one is *nolen gur* (liquid palm jaggery), which is my favourite sweet in the world.

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

with Bandeep Singh